Summer Bird Survey Report

The survey began at the northern gate, where the path divides into three tracks. Each track was walked twice, once in the morning and once in the late afternoon, and the observers noted every bird they heard or saw within twenty metres of the path.

Along the eastern track the hedges are tall and dense, and the most common birds were wrens, robins and blackbirds. The observers also recorded a pair of bullfinches feeding on the buds of the blackthorn near the old stile, which had not been seen there for several years.

The western track crosses open grassland. Skylarks sang over the meadow on both visits, and a kestrel hunted along the margin of the field for most of the afternoon. Meadow pipits were present in small numbers near the wet ground by the pond.

The central track runs through the wood. Here the counts were lower, but the variety was greater: great spotted woodpeckers, nuthatches, treecreepers and a single tawny owl roosting in an ivy-covered oak close to the ruined keeper cottage.

Changes Since Last Year

Compared with last year, the number of species recorded rose from thirty-one to thirty-six. The observers believe the new pond and the uncut field margins are the main reasons, since several of the new species depend on insects that breed in wet ground and long grass.

Several observers suggested extending the survey into the evening, because owls and bats were heard at dusk but could not be counted properly. The photographs of the pond margin, see Figure 1, show how much the vegetation has grown since the spring.

The committee will repeat the survey next summer with the same routes and timings, so that the results can be compared fairly. Volunteers who would like to join should contact the secretary before the end of the month, and new observers are always welcome.

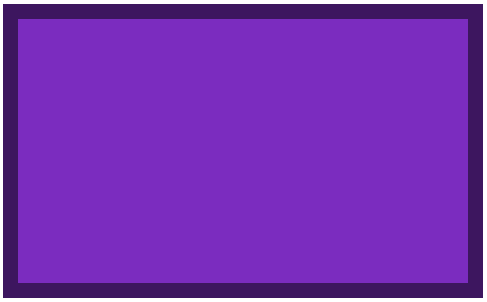

Figure 1: The pond margin in July

Finally, the group thanked the landowners for permission to walk the tracks, and the local school for lending binoculars to the younger volunteers who joined the morning walks during the holiday week.

Evening Walks

The evening walks began in August. Two observers with torches followed the central track after sunset and listened at five fixed points for ten minutes each, noting owls,

nightjars and anything else that called.

Tawny owls were heard at every point on every evening, often several at once, and a barn owl was seen quartering the meadow beside the western track on two occasions. Nightjars were not recorded this year.

On the warmest evening the observers stayed until midnight. Moths gathered around the torches in such numbers that one volunteer began counting them as well, and the group now hopes to borrow a light trap.

Bats were counted with a borrowed detector. Common and soprano pipistrelles fed along the hedges, and noctules flew high over the pond shortly after sunset. The detector also picked up a brown long-eared bat near the cottage ruins.

Hedgehogs crossed the track twice, and a fox watched the observers from the edge of the wood for several minutes before slipping away towards the farm. Neither had been noted on the daytime walks.

These results will be sent to the county recorder, together with the daytime counts, so that they can be added to the regional atlas. Copies of the full tables are available from the secretary on request.

The cost of the season was small: batteries for the torches, a new notebook for each observer and the hire of the detector for a fortnight. The society paid for all of it from the summer raffle.

Anyone interested in the evening walks next year should know that warm clothes and patience matter more than experience. The owls, it turns out, are happy to be counted by beginners.